



BECMI

Custom Class
Creation
Framework

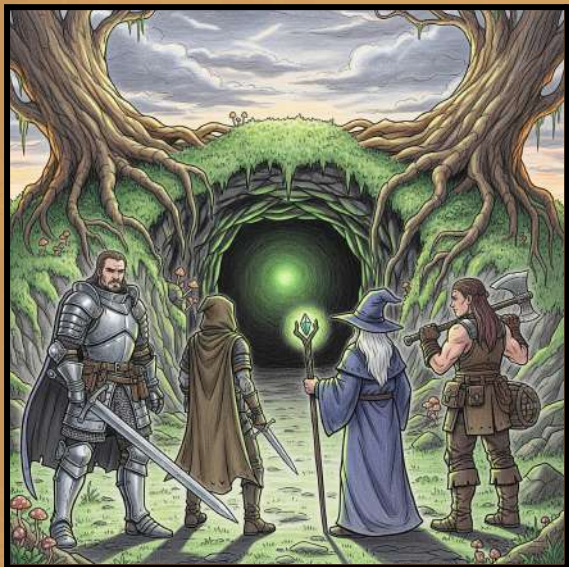
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Section I: The Anatomy of a BECMI Class - Reverse-Engineering the Core Design



The creation of new character classes for the Basic, Expert, Companion, Master, and Immortals (BECMI) ruleset, as consolidated in the Dungeons & Dragons Rules Cyclopedia, is not a matter of arbitrary selection but of methodical design—a crucial distinction in an era of increasingly rules-heavy roleplaying games. Unlike modern D&D, which often provides a rule for every conceivable situation, BECMI thrives on the principle of "rulings, not rules." This elegant internal logic means that while the Experience Point (XP) progression serves as the primary balancing mechanism, the Dungeon Master's informed judgment is paramount. Each class is a carefully assembled collection of abilities, restrictions, and combat potential, and the "cost" of this package is paid through the XP required to advance in level. By deconstructing the canonical classes, one can reveal the

foundational principles of this design and construct a framework for creating new classes that are both unique and balanced within the established ecosystem, empowering the Dungeon Master with the tools to make consistent and justifiable rulings. The BECMI Philosophy: Rulings, Not Rules

At the heart of BECMI D&D lies a design philosophy that prioritizes the Dungeon Master's narrative control and adjudicative power over an exhaustive set of predefined rules. This is a stark contrast to many contemporary roleplaying games, where players might expect a specific rule for every conceivable action or interaction. In BECMI, the rules provide a foundational framework, but the DM's interpretation and judgment are the ultimate arbiters of how those rules apply to a given situation. This "rulings, not rules" approach fosters a more dynamic and improvisational play experience, encouraging creativity and adaptability from both players and DMs. The Experience Point Economy as a Balancing Mechanism

Within this framework, the Experience Point (XP) progression system acts as the primary balancing mechanism for character classes. Unlike some systems that rely heavily on feat trees, skill point allocations, or complex mathematical formulas to define power levels, BECMI ties a character's advancement directly

to their accumulated XP. This means that a class with a steeper XP progression requirement for advancement is inherently considered to have a more powerful or versatile set of abilities, or perhaps fewer restrictions, than a class with a flatter progression. The "cost" of a class's overall package of abilities, special features, saving throws, and combat potential is directly reflected in how many XP are needed to gain each new level.

Deconstructing Canonical Classes:
Unveiling Design Principles

To effectively design new classes that feel authentic and balanced within the BECMi ecosystem, it is essential to first deconstruct the existing canonical classes. By examining the Fighters, Magic-Users, Clerics, Thieves, Dwarves, Elves, and Halflings, one can discern the underlying principles that guided their creation.

- **Ability Scores and Prerequisites:** Each class often has specific prime requisites or preferred ability scores that influence XP



gain, reflecting the core competencies expected of that class.

- **Hit Dice and Survivability:** The type and number of Hit Dice determine a class's inherent toughness and ability to withstand damage, signifying their role on the battlefield.
- **Saving Throws:** The progression and types of saving throws (Death Ray/Poison, Magic Wands, Paralysis/Turn to Stone, Dragon Breath, Spells) provide a measure of a class's resilience against various threats.
- **Combat Prowess:** This encompasses weapon and armor proficiencies, attack bonus progression, and any special combat-oriented abilities.
- **Special Abilities:** These are the unique powers and features that define a class, such as a Magic-User's spellcasting, a Cleric's turning undead, or a Thief's specialized skills. These abilities often come with specific restrictions or conditions for their use.
- **Restrictions and Limitations:** BECMi classes are often defined as much by what they cannot do as by what they can. Restrictions on armor, weapons, spell schools, or even alignment help to define the class's identity and balance its power.
- **XP Progression Table:** This is the most explicit indicator of a class's power level. Classes with more potent abilities or fewer restrictions typically require more XP to advance, ensuring a relative balance across different

character types.

A Framework for New Class Creation

By understanding these foundational elements, a Dungeon Master can develop a systematic framework for creating new classes that integrate seamlessly into BECMi campaigns:

1. Define the Class Concept and Niche: What unique role does this class fill in the adventuring party and the game world? What are its core themes and archetypes?
2. Establish Prime Requisites and Ability Score Dependencies:

Determine which ability scores are most crucial for the class's function, and how they will influence XP gain.

3. Assign Hit Dice and Survivability: Select an appropriate Hit Die type based on the class's intended resilience and combat role.
4. Design Saving Throw Progression: Tailor the saving throw values to reflect the class's strengths and weaknesses against different types of threats.
5. Determine Combat Proficiencies: Specify weapon and armor restrictions, as well as any



special combat abilities or limitations.

6. **Craft Unique Special Abilities:** Invent abilities that are flavorful, mechanically distinct, and consistent with the class's concept. Pay close attention to how these abilities interact with existing rules.
7. **Implement Appropriate Restrictions:** Introduce limitations that balance the class's special abilities and prevent it from overshadowing other classes.
8. **Develop an XP Progression Table:** This is the critical balancing act. Based on the aggregate power, versatility, and restrictions of the class, create an XP progression that aligns with the established canon. A more powerful class will require more XP per level, and vice-versa.
9. **Test and Refine:** Playtest the new class extensively to identify any unforeseen power imbalances, ambiguities, or areas where the "rulings, not rules" principle needs to be applied.

Empowering the Dungeon Master with this methodical design approach ensures that new character classes are not only imaginative and exciting but also maintain the internal consistency and delicate balance that are hallmarks of the BECMI ruleset, fostering a richer and more cohesive roleplaying experience for everyone at the table.



1.1 The Four Pillars: Establishing the Baselines

The foundation of the BECMI system rests upon four core human classes: the Fighter, the Cleric, the Magic-User, and the Thief. A detailed mechanical analysis of these archetypes reveals the fundamental trade-offs that govern the game's balance.

The **Fighter** represents the martial baseline. Requiring only 2,000 XP to reach 2nd level, it possesses the fastest progression in the game. This rapid advancement is a direct consequence of its focused design. The Fighter's primary role is combat, a fact reinforced by its 1d8 Hit Die (the highest available to a starting character), its unrestricted access to all armor and weapons, and its eventual acquisition of specialized combat maneuvers.¹ Its lack of complex subsystems, such as spellcasting or intricate skills, allows it to excel in the core metrics of survivability and martial prowess, rewarding the player with swift and tangible gains in power.

In stark contrast, the **Magic-User** exemplifies the principle of delayed gratification. Requiring 2,500 XP for 2nd level and featuring an exponentially steeper curve thereafter, its progression is the slowest of the core classes. This significant XP cost is the deliberate price for its eventual, reality-altering power. The Magic-User begins as the most fragile character, with a mere 1d4 Hit Die and a prohibition on wearing any armor.¹ Its initial contribution is limited to a single 1st-level spell per day. However, as the Magic-User advances, this initial vulnerability gives way to immense power, with access to spells that can alter the battlefield, bypass

obstacles, and inflict devastating damage.¹ The slow progression serves as a crucial gate, preventing this power from dominating the early stages of a campaign.



The **Cleric** and the **Thief** occupy intermediate positions, balancing unique abilities against combat effectiveness. The Cleric, with a 1d6 Hit Die and a requirement of 1,500 XP for 2nd level, has a faster progression than the Fighter. This is balanced by a significant weapon restriction—the



inability to use edged or pointed weapons—and a spellcasting progression that begins at 2nd level.¹ Its core abilities, Turning Undead and casting divine spells, provide unique and vital party support that is distinct from raw combat power.

The **Thief**, with a 1d4 Hit Die and needing 1,200 XP for 2nd level, has the fastest progression of all. This is the compensation for its fragility and moderate combat ability (leather armor only, no shields). The Thief's value is not in direct confrontation but in its exclusive suite of skills: Open Locks, Find and Remove Traps, Climb Walls, Move Silently, Hide in Shadows, and Pick Pockets. These abilities allow the party to circumvent challenges that are

difficult or impossible for other classes, creating a distinct niche that is paid for with lower combat survivability.

This analysis reveals a causal relationship between a class's abilities and its XP progression. The designers established a "power budget" for each class, paid for in the currency of experience points. The simplicity of the Fighter is rewarded with speed, while the potential of the Magic-User is gated by a steep cost.

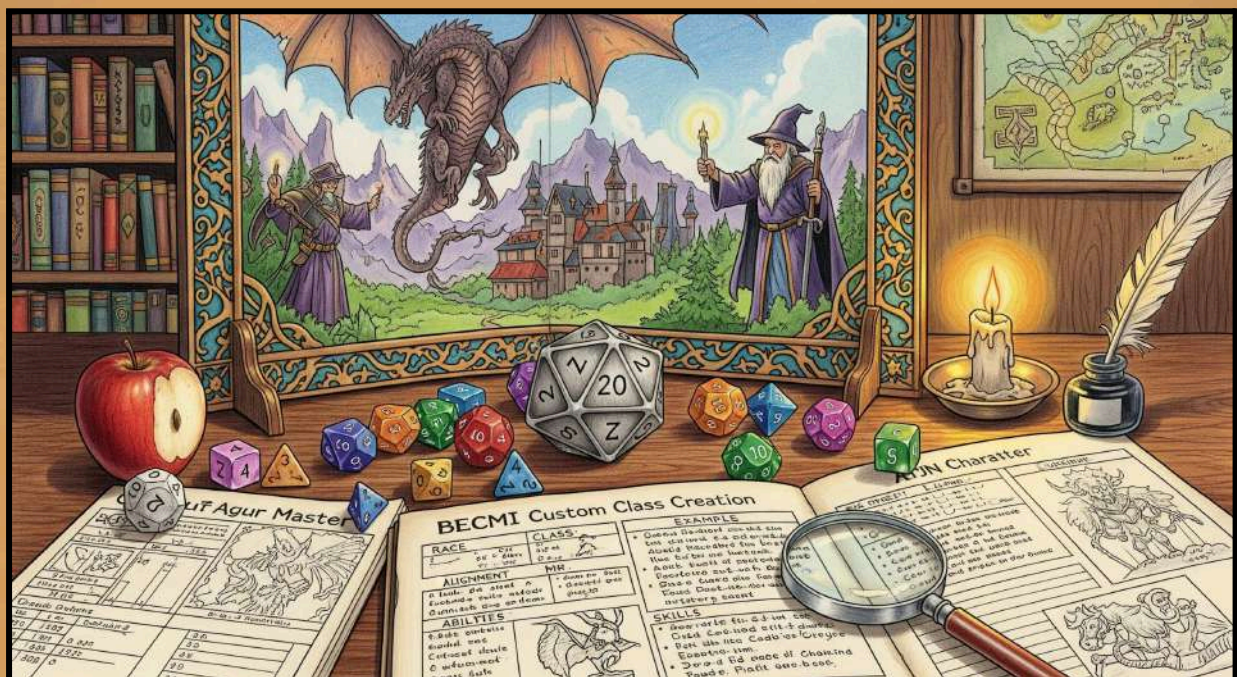


Table 1-A: Core Class Component Matrix

Component	Fighter	Cleric	Magic-User	Thief
Prime Requisite	Strength	Wisdom	Intelligence	Dexterity
Hit Die (HD)	1d8	1d6	1d4	1d4
XP to 2nd Level	2,000	1,500	2,500	1,200
Armor Permitted	Any, plus shield	Any, plus shield	None	Leather only
Weapons Permitted	Any	Blunt weapons only	Dagger only (optional others)	Any one-handed melee, any missile
Core Abilities	Combat Maneuvers	Turn Undead, Clerical Spells (from L2)	Magical Spells (from L1)	Thief Skills, Backstab

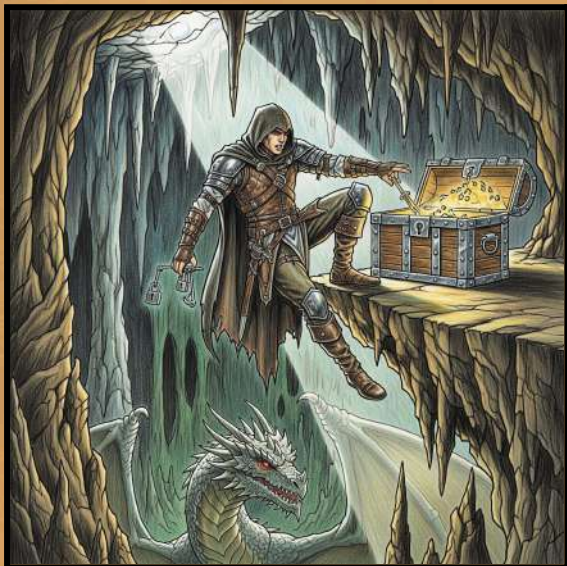
Data compiled from the Dungeons & Dragons Rules Cyclopedia, Chapter 2.

1.2 Hybrids and Specialists: The Cost of Versatility

Beyond the four human pillars, the BECM system introduces demihuman classes and optional human specialists that further illuminate the design principle of balancing power with XP cost. These classes demonstrate how versatility and unique, powerful abilities are paid for with significantly slower advancement.



The **Elf** is the quintessential hybrid class, blending the martial capabilities of the Fighter with the spellcasting of the Magic-User. An Elf can use any weapon and armor, possesses a respectable 1d6 Hit Die, and gains the ability to cast arcane spells. This versatility comes at a steep price: an Elf requires 4,000 XP to reach 2nd level, double that of a Fighter.¹ This extremely slow progression is the explicit cost for being able to function effectively in two distinct roles, ensuring that the Elf does not overshadow the more specialized Fighter or Magic-User at any given level.



The **Mystic** serves as a prime example of a specialist class. This optional human class is a master of unarmed combat, a role unique within the system. The Mystic is forbidden from wearing armor but compensates with a naturally improving Armor Class that progresses with each level. Its martial arts damage increases dramatically over its career, and it gains a host of special abilities, including some borrowed from the Thief (e.g., Move Silently, Climb Walls) and others that are entirely unique (e.g., Heal Self, Mind Block).¹ This potent and exclusive package of abilities is balanced

by a 1d6 Hit Die, strict equipment prohibitions, and a custom experience table that is slower than a Fighter's.

A subtle but critical pattern emerges when examining the Saving Throw progression tables for each class. Each of the four core archetypes possesses a distinct "Saving Throw Profile" that mechanically reinforces its conceptual role.

- **Fighters** excel against direct physical threats. A comparison of the saving throw tables shows they have superior saves versus Paralysis, Turn to Stone, and Dragon Breath.¹
- **Magic-Users** are more resilient against magical and esoteric attacks, possessing better saves versus Magic Wands and Spells/Rods/Staves.¹
- **Clerics** and **Thieves** occupy a middle ground, with a balanced progression that is generally better than a Fighter's against magic and better than a Magic-User's against physical effects.¹

This is not a random distribution of numbers but a deliberate design choice that further defines class identity. When



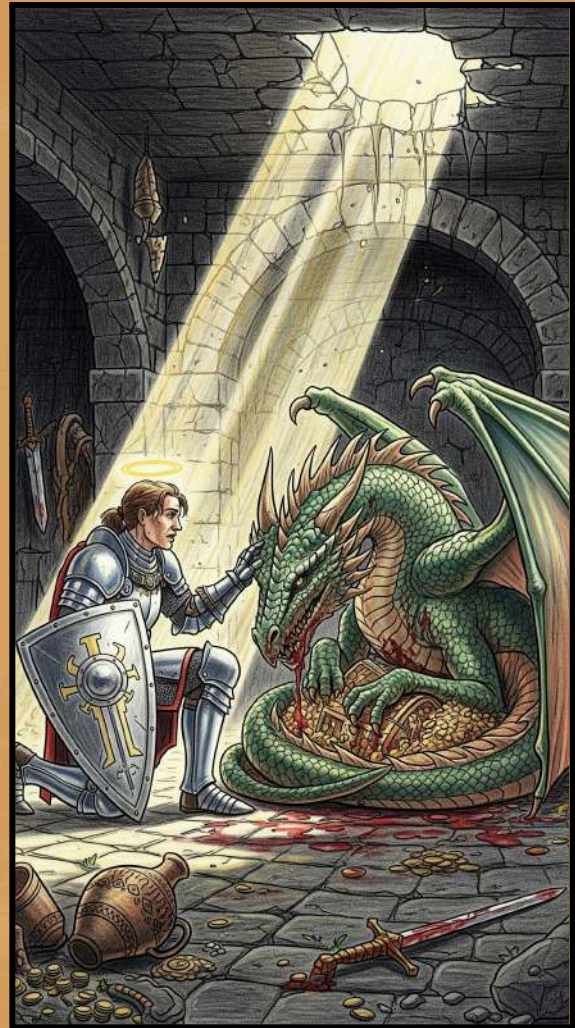
designing a new martial class like a Barbarian, it should logically inherit the Fighter's robust saving throw profile against physical dangers. Conversely, a new "expert" class like an Alchemist would be more appropriately assigned the Thief's balanced profile.

1.3 The High-Level Archetype: The Paladin as a Model

The *Rules Cyclopedia* provides a unique model for character advancement through the options available to Fighters who reach the 9th "Name" level. These paths—the Lawful Paladin, the Neutral Knight, and the Chaotic Avenger—are not subclasses chosen at character creation but rather "prestige paths" that grant powerful new abilities as a reward for long-term dedication to the Fighter class.¹

The **Paladin**, available to a Lawful Fighter of 9th level or higher, is the most illustrative example. Upon swearing fealty to a Lawful clerical order, the character gains a suite of potent abilities clearly borrowed from the Cleric class: the ability to *Detect Evil*, to Turn Undead as a cleric of one-third his level, and, if his Wisdom is 13 or higher, the ability to cast clerical spells.¹

This design reveals a crucial principle: powerful abilities can be "paid for" in one of two ways. The first is through a slower XP progression from the outset, as demonstrated by the Elf class. The second is through a significant "buy-in" of dedicated gameplay, as demonstrated by the Paladin. The nine levels of play as a pure Fighter represent the "cost" of



acquiring these divine powers.

This dual-cost model provides two distinct templates for balancing custom classes. A class that is powerful and versatile from 1st level must have a correspondingly slow XP progression. Alternatively, a class could begin with a focused, limited set of abilities and a faster progression, with the option to "unlock" more powerful and diverse abilities at higher levels after a significant investment of time and experience. If one wishes to create a Paladin class that is available from 1st level, the "time cost" of playing nine Fighter levels must be converted into a direct "XP cost" by designing a slower experience table from the very beginning. This understanding is the key

to adapting high-level options into fully realized, balanced classes.

Section II: The Architect's Toolkit: A Framework for Custom Class Creation

By translating the principles reverse-engineered from the canonical classes into a systematic process, a Dungeon Master can construct new classes that are balanced, thematic, and seamlessly integrated into the BECM framework. This toolkit provides a step-by-step methodology for this architectural process, transforming class design from an art into a science.

2.1 Step 1: Concept, Role, and Prime Requisite

The first step in creating any new class is to define its core identity. This begins with a clear, concise concept (e.g., "a holy warrior dedicated to justice," "a savage from the untamed wilds," "a master of herbalism and natural remedies"). This concept informs the class's intended role within an adventuring party: is it a front-line combatant, a support character, a scout, or a spellcaster?

Once the concept is established, one or two Prime Requisites must be selected from the six ability scores. The Prime Requisite is the mechanical anchor for the class concept, representing the character's most vital attribute.¹

- **Strength** is the natural choice for classes focused on melee combat (Fighter, Barbarian).
- **Intelligence** is suited for scholarly or arcane classes (Magic-User, Alchemist).
- **Wisdom** is the domain of divine or intuitive classes (Cleric, Druid, Paladin).
- **Dexterity** is key for agile or stealthy classes (Thief, Ranger).
- **Constitution** and **Charisma** are typically not used as sole Prime Requisites but can serve as secondary requirements or defining features.

A class may have two Prime Requisites, as seen with the Elf (Strength and Intelligence). This signifies a hybrid nature and typically warrants a slower XP progression. The experience point bonus granted for high Prime Requisite scores is a core, non-negotiable feature of any custom class and must be included to maintain consistency with the base game.¹



2.2 Step 2: The Chassis - Foundational Mechanics

With the concept defined, the next step is to select the class's foundational framework, or "chassis." This involves making three critical choices that determine the class's baseline survivability and combat potential.

1. **Hit Dice Selection:** The choice of Hit Die is a primary determinant of a class's role and resilience. The established archetypes provide a clear guide:
 - **1d8:** The standard for dedicated warrior classes (Fighter, Dwarf).
 - **1d6:** The choice for versatile or secondary combatants (Cleric, Elf, Mystic).
 - **1d4:** The standard for non-combat specialists and primary spellcasters (Magic-User, Thief).
2. **Saving Throw Selection:** As established in Section 1.2, each of the four core classes has a unique

saving throw progression that reflects its archetype. A new class should adopt the saving throw table of the core class it most closely resembles in function.

- **Fighter Saves:** For martial classes that face physical dangers head-on (Barbarian, Knight).
 - **Magic-User Saves:** For arcane classes or those who deal with esoteric energies (Wizard variants, Psionicist).
 - **Cleric Saves:** For divine or spiritually-focused classes (Paladin, Shaman).
 - **Thief Saves:** For skill-based specialists and agile skirmishers (Alchemist, Ranger, Bard).
3. **Armor and Weapon Proficiencies:** The permissions for armor and weapons further define a class's combat role and are a significant balancing factor. The spectrum ranges from the Magic-User's "None" to the Fighter's "Any".¹ Restrictions should be thematically

appropriate; a Barbarian might be forbidden from wearing heavy plate mail not because of physical inability, but because it clashes with their concept of a fast, ferocious warrior. Each level of permission, from "None" to "Leather Only" to "Any," carries an implicit cost that will be factored into the experience progression.

2.3 Step 3: The Engine of Balance - Calibrating the Experience Table

This is the most critical step in ensuring a custom class is balanced. The methodology involves a point-buy system where every class feature—from its Hit Dice to its special abilities—is assigned an "XP Value." The sum of these values is then used to calculate a custom experience point progression

table.⁴ This process transforms the abstract concept of game balance into a concrete, additive formula.

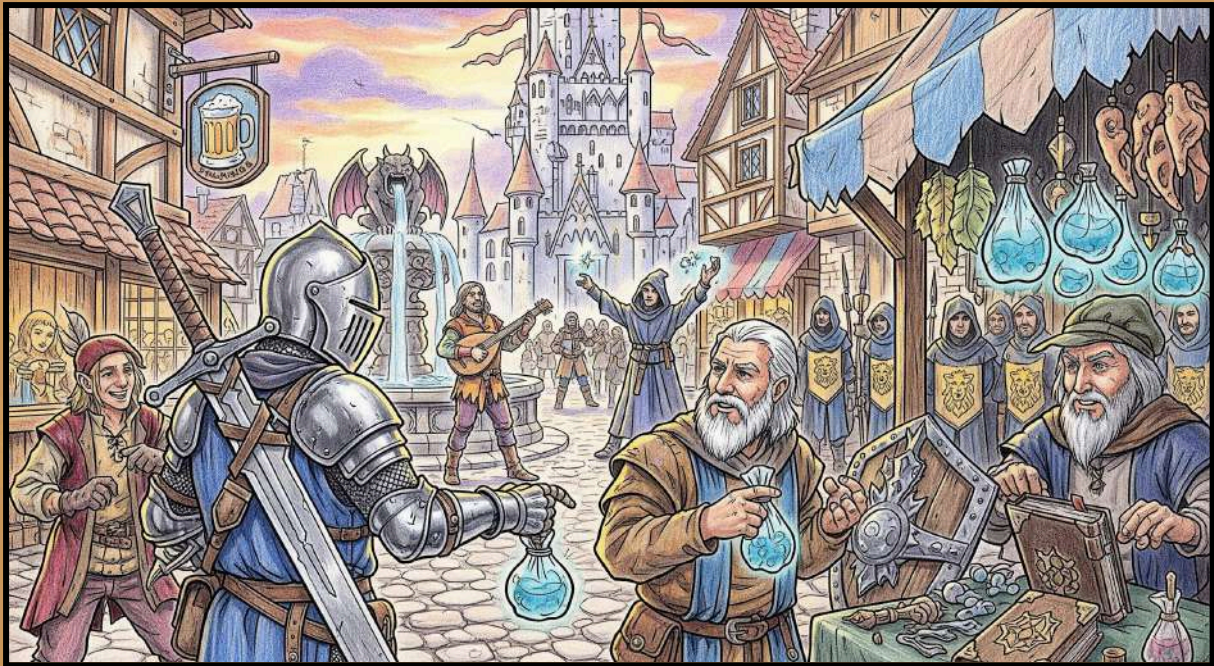
The **Fighter's XP table** serves as the baseline (XP Value), representing the fastest possible progression. Every ability that is "better" than a Fighter's adds to the total XP Value, while every restriction or ability that is "worse" provides a negative XP Value (a "credit"). The final sum determines the necessary XP to reach 2nd level, and subsequent levels are extrapolated from that benchmark.

The following table provides estimated XP Values for the core components of a BECMI class. These values are derived through a reverse-engineering of the canonical classes in the *Rules Cyclopedia*.



Table 2-A: The Grand Table of Ability XP Costs

Ability/Feature	XP Value	Notes
Baseline (Fighter)	0	Base XP for 1d8 HD, Fighter Saves, Any Armor/Weapons.
Hit Dice		
1d6 Hit Die	-250	Credit for lower survivability compared to 1d8.
1d4 Hit Die	-500	Credit for lowest survivability compared to 1d8.
Saving Throws		
Cleric/Thief Saves	+100	Slightly better magical resistance than Fighter.
Magic-User Saves	+200	Best magical resistance.
Armor Restrictions		
No Shield	-100	Credit for loss of a key defensive option.
Leather Armor Only	-250	Significant defensive restriction.
No Armor	-500	Maximum defensive restriction.
Weapon Restrictions		
One-Handed Only	-100	Credit for losing access to powerful two-handed weapons.
Blunt Weapons Only	-200	Significant offensive restriction (Cleric).
Dagger Only	-400	Maximum offensive restriction (Magic-User).
Core Class Abilities		
Full Thief Skills	+900	Complete package (OL, FT, RT, CW, MS, HS, PP, HN).
Full Cleric Spells	+1,150	Full progression, starting at L2.
Full Magic-User Spells	+2,000	Full progression, starting at L1.
Turn Undead (Cleric)	+400	Core, powerful class-defining ability.
Backstab (Thief)	+100	Situational but potent damage multiplier.
Fighter Combat Options	+250	Smash, Parry, Disarm (gained at Name Level).
Hybrid/Specialist Abilities		
Mystic Martial Arts	+1,200	Full progression of unarmed damage and magical properties.
Mystic AC Bonus	+800	Level-based AC improvement.
Elf Infravision/Immunities	+150	Minor but constant benefits.
Dwarf Detection/Saves	+250	Superior saving throws and detection abilities.



To use the table, one simply adds the values of the chosen components. For example, a calculation for the canonical **Elf** class would look like this:

- **Baseline (Fighter):**
- **Hit Dice (1d6):**
- **Saving Throws (Fighter):**
- **Armor/Weapons (Any):**
- **Magic-User Spells (Full):**
- **Infravision/Immunities:**
- **Total XP Value:**

The Fighter's base XP for level 2 is 2,000. Adding the Elf's total XP value gives XP. This is remarkably close to the official 4,000 XP required, demonstrating the internal consistency of the system. This method allows for the creation of a custom XP table that is mathematically sound and balanced against the existing classes.

2.4 Step 4: Signature

Abilities - Design and Costing

The final step is to design the unique, thematic abilities that define the new class and assign them a fair XP Value.

Adapting Existing Mechanics: The simplest method is to adapt an existing game mechanic. A Barbarian's "Intimidating Howl" might function once per day as a *Cause Fear* spell cast by a Cleric of half the Barbarian's level. This allows for straightforward costing by using a fraction of the value for "Clerical Spells." A Ranger's tracking ability can be costed as a free "Tracking" General Skill.¹

Creating New Mechanics: For entirely new abilities, such as a Barbarian's Rage, the XP Value can be estimated by considering three factors:

1. **Impact:** How significantly does the ability affect gameplay? A bonus of

to hit and damage is highly impactful.

2. **Frequency:** How often can it be used? An ability usable once per day is less costly than one usable in every combat.
3. **Duration:** How long does it last? An effect lasting for a few rounds is less costly than one lasting for a full turn.

A Barbarian's Rage, providing a bonus to attack and damage rolls but a penalty to AC for a number of rounds equal to the character's level, once per day, might be assigned an XP Value of . It is a powerful offensive boost (comparable to a low-level *Strength* spell) but comes with a significant defensive drawback and is limited in use.

This XP-cost framework is a powerful diagnostic tool for any DM. It can be used not only to create new classes but also to balance variants of existing ones or to fairly price the addition of house-ruled abilities. If a player wishes for their Fighter to learn the Thief's Climb Walls skill, the DM can consult the framework, determine a fair XP cost for that single skill, and create a custom, slightly slower XP table for that specific character. This allows for deep, meaningful character customization while preserving the mathematical integrity of the game's core design.





Section III: Practical Application - Case Studies in Class Design

The theoretical framework established in Section II is best understood through practical application. This section provides three complete, playable class designs based on the user's examples: the Paladin, the Barbarian, and the Alchemist. Each case study demonstrates the step-by-step process of concept definition, chassis selection, ability costing, and XP table calibration.

3.1 Case Study: The Paladin (Levels 1-36)

Goal: To engineer the high-level Fighter option into a full base class available from 1st level.

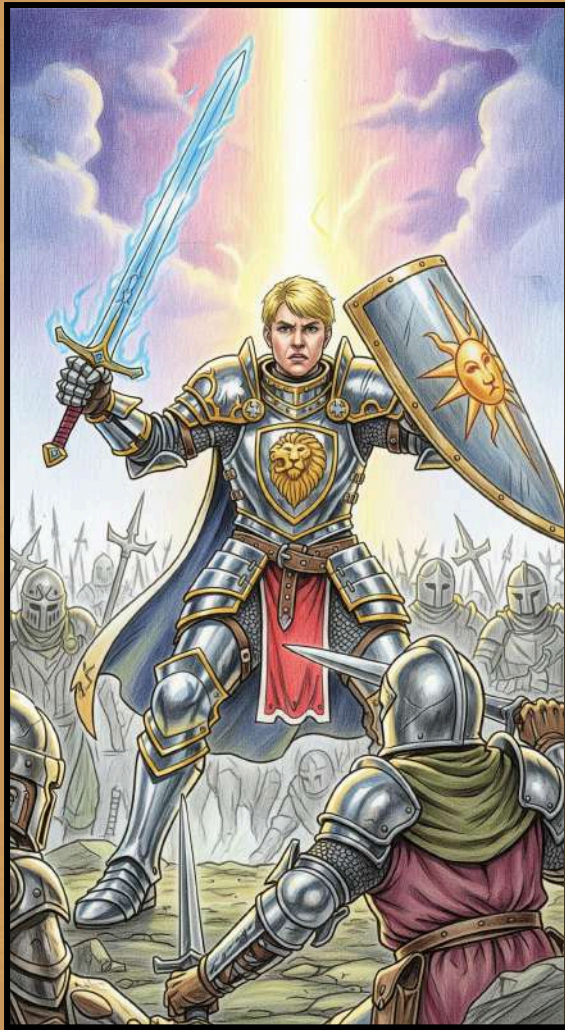
1. Concept, Role, and Prime Requisites:

The concept is a holy warrior, a champion of Law and good. The role is a

front-line combatant with secondary divine support abilities. The Prime Requisites will be **Strength** and **Wisdom**. A Strength of 13+ and Wisdom of 13+ will grant an XP bonus.

2. Chassis Selection:

- **Hit Dice:** 1d8, consistent with a primary warrior role.
- **Saving Throws:** Fighter table, reflecting martial resilience.
- **Armor/Weapons:** Any armor and weapons, same as the Fighter.



3. Signature Abilities (Design and Costing): We will adapt the abilities granted to the 9th-level Paladin in the *Rules Cyclopedia* and cost them for a 1st-level character.¹

- **Detect Evil:** Usable at will. A potent, constant information-gathering tool. Costed as a significant utility ability. (XP Value:)
- **Lay on Hands:** A non-spell healing ability. We will define it as healing 2 hit points per level of the Paladin, usable once per day. This is less flexible than a *Cure Light Wounds* spell but scales reliably. (XP Value:)
- **Turn Undead:** The ability to Turn Undead as a Cleric of two levels lower than the Paladin (e.g., a 3rd-level Paladin turns as a 1st-level

Cleric). (XP Value: , less than the full Cleric ability).

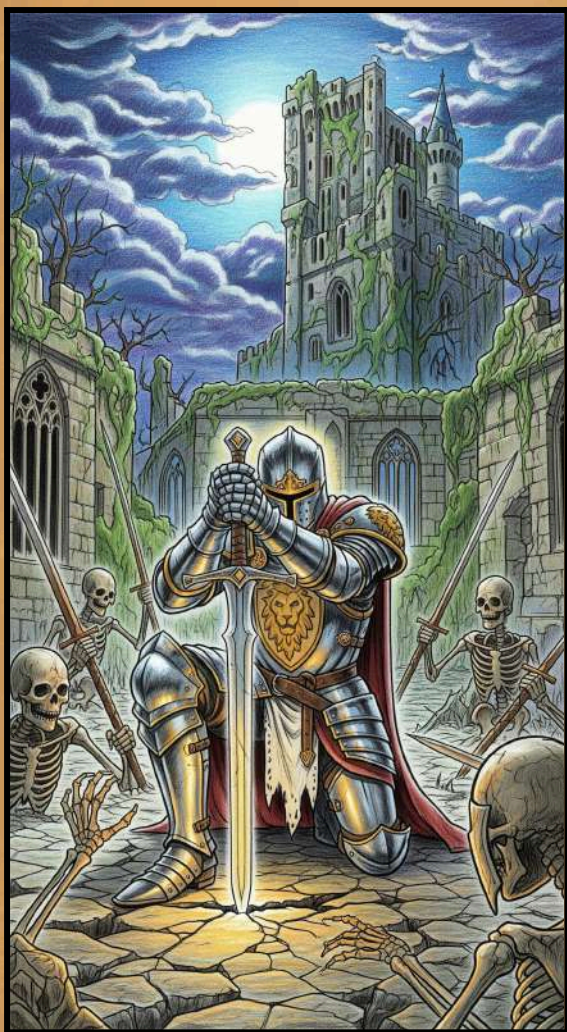
- **Limited Clerical Spells:** The Paladin will gain access to Cleric spells at 4th level, progressing as a Cleric of three levels lower. This delayed and reduced spellcasting is powerful but significantly less so than a full Cleric's. (XP Value:).
- **Restrictions:** The Paladin must be of Lawful alignment and adhere to a strict code of conduct. While this has no direct XP Value, it is a significant role-playing constraint that balances the class's power.

4. Experience Table Calibration:

- **Baseline (Fighter):**
- **Hit Dice (1d8):**
- **Saving Throws (Fighter):**
- **Armor/Weapons (Any):**
- **Detect Evil:**
- **Lay on Hands:**
- **Turn Undead (Reduced):**
- **Clerical Spells (Reduced):**
- **Total XP Value:**

The base XP for a Fighter to reach 2nd level is 2,000. The Paladin's total is XP. We will round this to a cleaner **3,500 XP** for 2nd level. The subsequent progression will be steeper than a Fighter's but faster than an Elf's.





Paladin Class Summary

- **Prime Requisites:** Strength, Wisdom
- **Hit Dice:**
- **Armor:** Any, plus shield
- **Weapons:** Any
- **Saving Throws:** As Fighter
- **Special Abilities:** Must be Lawful. Detects evil at will. Lays on hands to heal 2 HP/level once per day. At 3rd level, turns undead as a Cleric of two levels lower. At 4th level, gains Cleric spells as a Cleric of three levels lower. Gains Fighter Combat Options at 9th level.

Paladin Experience Table

Level	XP	Title
1	0	Gallant
2	3,500	Keeper
3	7,000	Protector
...	...	...
9	400,000	Crusader
...	...	...
36	4,200,000	Paladin, 36th Lvl



3.2 Case Study: The Barbarian

Goal: To design a new martial class distinct from the Fighter, focused on primal fury and wilderness survival.

1. Concept, Role, and Prime Requisites:

The concept is a fierce, untamed warrior from the wilds. The role is a high-damage front-line combatant. The Prime Requisite will be **Strength**.

2. Chassis Selection:

- **Hit Dice:** 1d8, as a primary warrior.
- **Saving Throws:** Fighter table.
- **Armor/Weapons:** Any weapon. Armor is restricted to Leather and shields; no metal armor heavier than chain mail is permitted. This thematic restriction also serves as a key balancing factor.

3. Signature Abilities (Design and Costing):

- **Barbarian Rage:** Once per day, the Barbarian can enter a rage for a number of rounds equal to their level. While raging, they gain a

bonus on all attack and damage rolls but suffer a penalty to their Armor Class. (XP Value:)

- **Wilderness Skills:** The Barbarian automatically has the equivalent of the Tracking and Survival (Forest/Hills) general skills.¹ (XP Value:)
- **Armor Restriction:** Cannot wear plate mail or suit armor. This is a significant defensive limitation compared to the Fighter. (XP Value:)

4. Experience Table Calibration:

- **Baseline (Fighter):**
- **Hit Dice (1d8):**
- **Saving Throws (Fighter):**
- **Armor Restriction (No Plate):**
- **Weapons (Any):**
- **Barbarian Rage:**
- **Wilderness Skills:**
- **Total XP Value:**

The Fighter's base XP for level 2 is 2,000. The Barbarian's total is XP. We will set this at **2,500 XP** for 2nd level, making the Barbarian's progression slightly slower than a Fighter's, reflecting their added special abilities.

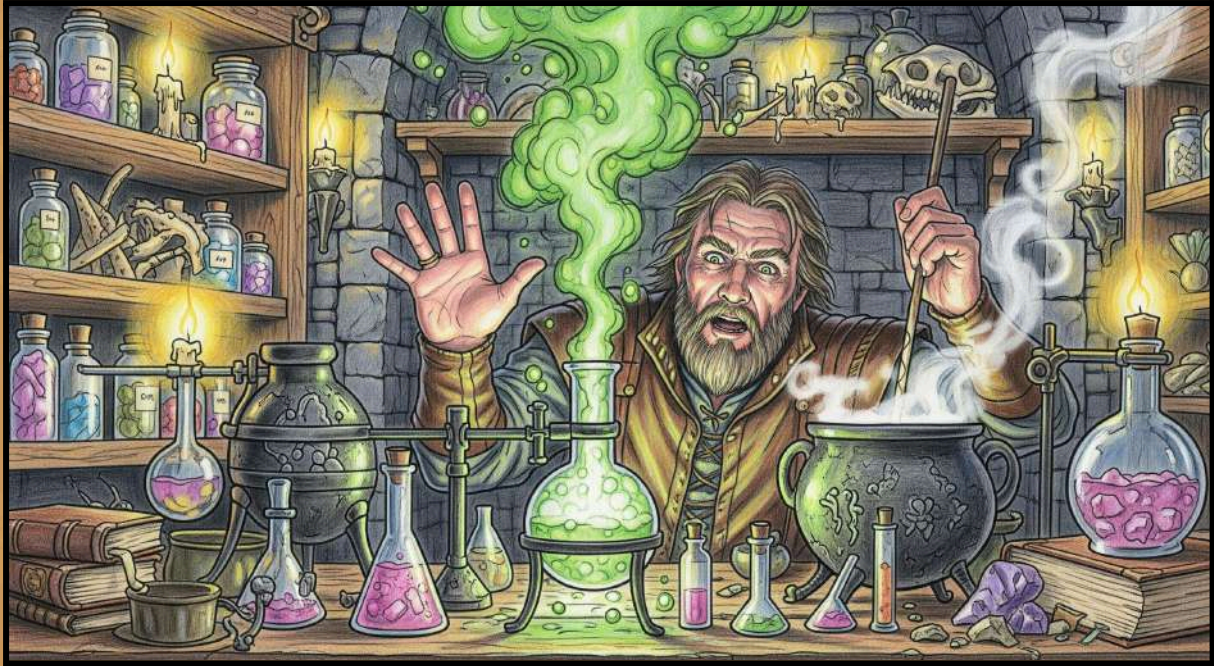


Barbarian Class Summary

- **Prime Requisite:** Strength
- **Hit Dice:**
- **Armor:** Leather, Chain Mail, Shields. No Plate Mail.
- **Weapons:** Any
- **Saving Throws:** As Fighter
- **Special Abilities:** Can Rage once per day. Automatically proficient in tracking and survival in their native terrain. Gains Fighter Combat Options at 9th level.

Barbarian Experience Table

Level	XP	Title
1	0	Savage
2	2,500	Raider
3	5,000	Berserker
...	...	...
9	300,000	Chieftain
...	...	...
36	3,900,000	Barbarian, 36th Lvl



3.3 Case Study: The Alchemist

Goal: To create a non-magical "expert" class focused on crafting potions, poultices, and other chemical concoctions.

1. Concept, Role, and Prime Requisites:

The concept is a scholarly artisan who manipulates natural and chemical substances. The role is a support character and problem-solver, with limited combat ability. The Prime Requisite will be **Intelligence**.

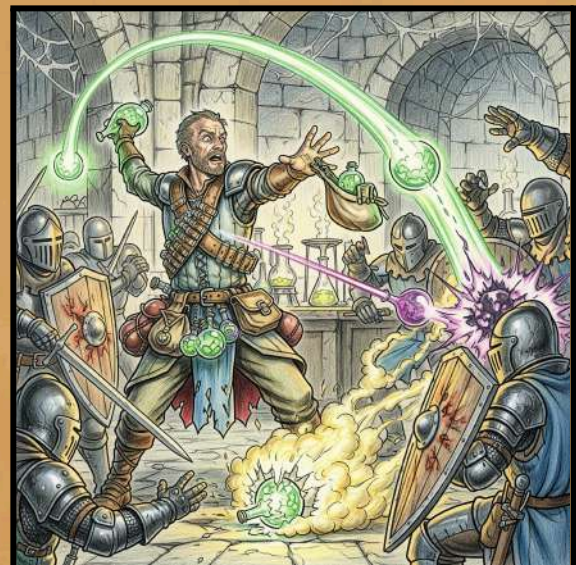
2. Chassis Selection:

- **Hit Dice:** 1d4, reflecting a non-combat focus.
- **Saving Throws:** Thief table, for a balanced profile.
- **Armor/Weapons:** Leather armor, no shield. Permitted weapons include dagger, staff, sling, and throwing oil/acid.

3. Signature Abilities (Design and Costing):

The Alchemist's core abilities will be a custom skill set that replaces the Thief's. The overall "cost" should be similar to the Thief's package.

- **Alchemical Skills:** A percentage-based skill progression similar to the Thief's, but with different abilities:
 - **Identify Substance:** Chance to





identify potions, poisons, and unknown materials.

- **Create Poulitice:** A non-magical healing ability. Once per day per subject, can restore 1d3 hit points. The chance of success starts low and increases with level.
- **Neutralize Poison:** Chance to counteract a poison's effects if treated within 10 rounds.
- **Formulate:** The ability to create simple alchemical items (acid,

alchemist's fire, smoke bombs) from components. The number of formulas known and the complexity increases with level.

- **Total XP Value for Skill Package:**
We will cost this package to be roughly equivalent to the Thief's skills. (XP Value:)

4. Experience Table Calibration:

- **Baseline (Fighter):**
- **Hit Dice (1d4):**
- **Saving Throws (Thief):**
- **Armor Restriction (Leather):**
- **Weapon Restrictions (Limited):**
- **Alchemical Skills:**
- **Total XP Value:**

The Fighter's base XP is 2,000. The Alchemist's total is XP. This is slightly faster than the Fighter, but slower than the Thief or Cleric. We will set the value at **1,800 XP** for 2nd level. This reflects a class that is less combat-capable than a Cleric but possesses more complex and useful abilities than a standard Fighter, without the risk-based nature of the Thief.

Alchemist Class Summary

- **Prime Requisite:** Intelligence
- **Hit Dice:**
- **Armor:** Leather only, no shield
- **Weapons:** Dagger, Staff, Sling, Thrown concoctions
- **Saving Throws:** As Thief
- **Special Abilities:** A unique set of Alchemical Skills with percentage-based progression.

Alchemist Experience Table

Level	XP	Title
1	0	Apprentice
2	1,800	Journeyman
3	3,600	Expert
...	...	...
9	200,000	Master
...	...	...
36	3,100,000	Alchemist, 36th Lvl



Section IV: Integration, Advancement, and Campaign Balance

The creation of a custom class does not end with its initial design. Proper integration into a campaign requires consideration of its long-term progression and its impact on the game world. A well-designed class should not only be balanced at 1st level but should also offer a compelling path of advancement and feel like a natural part of the campaign setting.



4.1 Beyond Level 9: Designing Name-Level Benefits

A defining feature of the BECM1 system is the concept of the "Name Level" (typically 9th level), at which point characters transcend the role of mere adventurers and can become significant figures in the world.¹ A Fighter can attract followers and build a stronghold

to become a Baron, a Cleric can become a Patriarch and establish a clerical seat of power, and a Magic-User can construct a wizard's tower, attracting apprentices.¹

When designing a custom class, it is essential to create an appropriate and thematic Name-Level benefit. This provides a long-term goal for the player and integrates the class into the campaign's political and social landscape.

- For the **Paladin**, upon reaching 9th level (Crusader), the character could be granted the right by their clerical order to establish a chapter house or a fortified commandery. This would attract not only standard men-at-arms but also a small number of lower-level Paladins-in-training (acolytes) who would serve as loyal retainers.
- For the **Barbarian**, reaching 9th level (Chieftain) would grant the character great renown among their people. If they return to their homeland, they could challenge for leadership of their tribe. Success would grant them command over a horde of warriors, not as paid mercenaries, but as loyal followers who will fight for the glory of the clan.
- For the **Alchemist**, upon reaching 9th level (Master), the character could establish a guild or laboratory. This would function as a stronghold, attracting apprentices and generating income through the sale of alchemical goods. The

Master Alchemist could dispatch apprentices on quests to find rare ingredients, creating new adventure hooks.

These benefits should be modeled on the existing rules for strongholds and followers, ensuring they provide a tangible reward for high-level play without unbalancing the campaign.¹

4.2 The Ripple Effect: Adjudication and World-Building

The introduction of a new class is more than a mechanical adjustment; it is a profound act of world-building. The existence of a playable Alchemist class implies that alchemy is a recognized and viable discipline within the campaign setting. This has consequences that the Dungeon Master must consider. If Alchemists exist, there must be guilds, masters, and sources for their specialized knowledge and materials. Their ability to create healing poultices might mean that clerical healing is less of a monopoly in remote villages, subtly altering the social and economic fabric

of the world. The presence of a Barbarian class suggests the existence of untamed lands and the cultures that inhabit them.

The DM must be prepared to adjudicate the use of new class abilities in unforeseen situations. A Barbarian's Rage is straightforward in combat, but how does it function in social situations? Does it impose penalties on Charisma-based checks? Can an Alchemist use their Identify Substance skill to analyze the magical properties of a dragon's blood? These questions require consistent and fair rulings that honor the class concept without allowing it to overshadow other characters.

Ultimately, the successful integration of a custom class depends on the DM's ability to weave it into the narrative of the campaign. The class should have a place in the world's history, its societies, and its conflicts. By considering these "ripple effects," the DM can transform a set of custom mechanics into a living, breathing part of the campaign, enriching the experience for all players and ensuring that the new creation feels as though it has always belonged.

